PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #31 · DEPRESSION

“My situation is hopeless.”

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Where it often comes from

Hard seasons teach the mind to expect more of the same. A long illness, a loss, a failed effort, money trouble, or a relationship that will not mend can make “this will never change” feel like a fact. Depression itself can darken the view, so the feeling of hopelessness arrives before any new evidence. The thought is understandable. It is still a conclusion, not a proof. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 in the United States, or tell someone near you right away.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture does not pretend that hard days are light. The writer of Lamentations felt consumed, and still said he had hope, because the Lord’s mercies never fail and are new every morning. The psalmist, downcast in his own soul, told himself to put his hope in God. Paul described being hard pressed and perplexed, but not in despair. These passages do not promise that every problem ends on our timetable. They do say that a painful situation is not the same thing as a hopeless one, and that the Lord is near the brokenhearted.

> *“Why are you downcast, O my soul? Why the unease within me? Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise Him, my Savior and my God”* (Psalm 42:11).

Also see

> “Yet I call this to mind, and therefore I have hope: Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!” (Lamentations 3:21–23).

> “We are hard pressed on all sides, but not crushed; perplexed, but not in despair; persecuted, but not forsaken; struck down, but not destroyed” (2 Corinthians 4:8–9).

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “Now may the God of hope fill you with all joy and peace as you believe in Him, so that you may overflow with hope by the power of the Holy Spirit” (Romans 15:13).

Common self-statements

- Nothing about this can change.
- I am stuck, and there is no way through.
- Hope is for other people, not for me.
- Whatever I try, it will not matter.
- This is as good as life will get.
- I might as well stop looking for a way forward.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Deciding the future is already closed because today feels dark.
- Overgeneralization: Turning one hard problem into “everything is hopeless.”
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling hopeless and treating the feeling as proof.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing the situation as either fully fixed or completely ruined.

Challenging questions

- What exactly feels hopeless, and what part of it is still unknown?
- Have I ever called something hopeless that later changed, even a little?
- What would I tell a friend who said the same words about a similar trouble?
- Who could I tell today, and what help have I not asked for yet?
- Is this a fact about the situation, or a feeling that depression is amplifying?
- What is one small step that does not require the whole problem to be solved?

Truth summary

> This situation is hard, and it is not hopeless. God is near, and I can take one step and ask for help today. A hard situation can be real without being the final word. His mercies are new this morning.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Hopeless
- Depression, Symptoms of
- Sorrow
- God, All Loving
- Thinking, Healthy

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Depression
- Suffering
- Thinking, Healthy

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Living Hope — Phil Wickham

Christ's resurrection says this hard chapter is not the end.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns

When strength and explanations run out, God's care is still holding you.

Oh My Soul — Casting Crowns

You can be honestly downcast and still put your hope in God.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans

Mercies are new every morning, even when the situation has not cleared.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "My situation is hopeless."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My situation is hopeless." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly feels hopeless, and what part is still unknown?
- ☐ Have I called something hopeless that later changed?
- ☐ What would I tell a friend in this same trouble?
- ☐ Who could I tell, and what help have I not asked for?
- ☐ Is this a fact, or a feeling that depression is amplifying?
- ☐ What one small step does not require the whole problem to be solved?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ This situation is hard, and it is not hopeless. God is near, and I can take one step and ask for help today.
- ☐ God is near me when I am brokenhearted.
- ☐ His mercies are new this morning.
- ☐ I do not have to solve everything today.
- ☐ I can ask for help.
- ☐ Feelings of despair are not the final word.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 42:11
  "Why are you downcast, O my soul? Why the unease within me? Put your hope in God, for I will yet praise Him, my Savior and my God."
- ☐ Lamentations 3:21–23
  "Yet I call this to mind, and therefore I have hope: Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!"
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 4:8–9
  "We are hard pressed on all sides, but not crushed; perplexed, but not in despair; persecuted, but not forsaken; struck down, but not destroyed."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When the "hopeless" feeling came: Each day, write down one moment when the situation felt closed. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 42:11 becomes: "Sarah can write: "My soul is downcast, but I will put my hope in God. This situation is hard, and it is not hopeless.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Hopeless" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If you are thinking about ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Name what is actually unknown. Write one sentence about what feels closed, and one sentence about what you do not know yet.
- [ ] Tell one safe person. Say, "This feels hopeless," to a trusted friend, family member, pastor, or counselor. Notice whether you are as alone as the belief says.
- [ ] Take one small step. Do one task you have been avoiding because it seemed pointless, and write down what you were able to do.
- [ ] Get help for what is real. If the trouble is a true danger, such as abuse or not having food or housing, or if you are thinking about suicide, take one step toward help this week. In the United States, call or text 988.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie “My situation is hopeless.”: _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment that was not hopeless
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My situation is hopeless.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, this situation feels closed, and I am tired of hoping. You are near the brokenhearted, and Your mercies are new this morning. Help me take one honest step and ask for the help I need. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.